Textual Practice

ISSN: 0950-236X (Print) 1470-1308 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/rtpr20

The alienation of Valerii Pereleshin

Caio Yurgel

To cite this article: Caio Yurgel (16 Jan 2026): The alienation of Valerii Pereleshin, Textual Practice, DOI: 10.1080/0950236X.2025.2612059

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/0950236X.2025.2612059

Published online: 16 Jan 2026.

Submit your article to this journal

Article views: 13

View related articles

View Crossmark data

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=rtpr20

TEXTUAL PRACTICE
https://doi.org/10.1080/0950236X.2025.2612059

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

Check for updates

The alienation of Valerii Pereleshin*

Caio Yurgel

Department of Humanities, Duke Kunshan University, Suzhou, People's Republic of China

ABSTRACT
Valerii Pereleshin, a Russian-Chinese-Brazilian poet, translator, and monk, remains an underexplored and virtually unknown figure despite a life that spanned pivotal political and cultural moments of the twentieth century. Born in 1913 in Russia and dying in obscurity in Brazil in 1992, Pereleshin's experiences of displacement, queerness, and marginality were central to his identity, yet he has largely been relegated to the periphery of literary scholarship. This article reinterprets his work through the Hegelian notion of alienation (*Entäusserung*), arguing that alienation is not a deficit but the very condition of freedom. Rather than a source of suffering, alienation enables subjectivity to emerge through misinterpretation, self-division, and eccentricity. Drawing on queer theory and psychoanalysis, and working within the broader Hegelian-psychoanalytic tradition, the article examines how Pereleshin's queerness unsettles conventional notions of identity and belonging, casting alienation as a dynamic process of becoming. Pereleshin's life and poetry demonstrate how freedom arises from the disruption of social norms and expectations, rejecting the myth of coherence or unity. By reclaiming alienation as a generative force, this study shows how transformation – of the self and the collective – occurs not through harmony but through shared dissonance.

ARTICLE HISTORY Received 5 March 2025; Accepted 8 December 2025

KEYWORDS Valerii Pereleshin; alienation (*Entäusserung*); queerness; camp; Russian émigré literature

> The whole adventure is too painful to speak of it, so I am sending this copy. Defeated once more, I shall have to lick my wounds until they are healed. After all, I am Brazilian, and free. – Pereleshin in a handwritten note to Carol L. Anschütz, University of Texas at Austin[1]

CONTACT Caio Yurgel cdy3@duke.edu

*This article has greatly benefited from conversations and research conducted with my colleague Zairong Xiang and the students Zhang Tianyu and Xue Chenghan, who assisted with archival research in China and the United States, as well as from Anastasia Titarova, whose invaluable support with the Russian translations has been essential throughout this text.

© 2026 Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group

Alienation as the condition of freedom

Subjectivity is the torsion of the self: we are who we are only because we are at odds with ourselves and the world. The discomfort of being – like the sudden pain of a stiff neck when turning too quickly – is the basis of our freedom. We are free not because we can choose, but because we can see ourselves in the external world while simultaneously feeling dislocated from it. Try as we may, our interpretation of the world and of the other is always a misinterpretation – and that is the source of our freedom. If our readings of the world and of others were ever 'correct,' no room would remain for the other's interpretation. To be with others *is* to be misinterpreted – and language does a healthy bit of the heavy lifting. We are free because we are wrong, because there is no autonomous substance we can ground ourselves on, because '[t]he self's sense of its subjectivity and independence develops not naturally or in a linear fashion but out of the experience of self-opposition, the experience of finding the world and its substance inadequate to it, alien.'[2] We are free because we come together in our alienation.

Freedom is the never-ending doubt over whether we are free at all, and as such it is traumatic: it requires some sort of subjective sacrifice. Mari Ruti suggests that instead of trying to 'drown or deaden our sentiments of lack or alienation,' we might take a decisive step toward happiness by learning from the lessons such discomfort holds: 'our ability to tarry with the negative, to express the matter in Hegelian terms – is indispensable for our psychic aliveness.'[3] We are disturbing to ourselves, which perhaps explains why we have become so addicted to screens: behind a screen we can preserve the illusion that we are not at odds with ourselves or with the world around us – for a time. Yet psychic aliveness requires the opposite – it means accepting, or at least grasping, the liberating awkwardness of being misinterpreted and misrecognised. The moment a teenager starts feeling awkward around their parents, embarrassed by them, is the moment they begin to break free from them: through alienation they acquire their own subjectivity, they become their own person. Paraphrasing Todd McGowan's reading of Hegel, I would propose that to be misinterpreted and misrecognised 'does not involve respect for otherness but the ability to see one's own self-division expressed in a different form in the other. One must see the other's alienation as the basis for the shared bond that exists.'[4] Freedom is not wholeness but fraction, and we come together in our alienation.

By this point it should be clear that 'alienation' (*Entäusserung*) is meant here not in the Marxian sense, but in the Hegelian – or, more broadly, Hegelian-psychoanalytic – one: alienation not as a problem to be solved, but as a condition to be embraced, a discomfort to remain with. For Hegel, alienation is a necessary component of both our subjectivity and of society as a whole; it

is not the negation of freedom but its very condition. His philosophy, in many ways, is an attempt to trace how this constitutive torsion – or, rather, contradiction – of the self plays out. What makes Hegel's philosophy so compelling (and the reason why it has been so influential across centuries and disciplines) is that it is all about the drama of being – you could almost read him as a (rather verbose) writer of fiction. In what follows, I shall play up this drama by making three counterintuitive claims in light of the life and work of the equally counterintuitive Russian-Chinese-Brazilian poet, translator, and monk Valerii Pereleshin:

1) That patriotic feelings are signs of unfreedom;
2) That to be social means keeping your distance from the other;
3) And that what we love in the other are the things that are not there, even – or especially – when the loved one is standing right in front of us.

Enter stage left: Valerii Pereleshin

Valerii Pereleshin (Вале́рий Переле́шин) was born Valery Frantsevich Salatko-Petrishche in Irkutsk, Russia, in 1913, and died Valério Pereliéchin in Rio de Janeiro, Brazil, in 1992. He grew up in Harbin – then a Russian colony, now a Chinese megacity – where he studied Law before becoming a monk with the Russian Orthodox Church. He served in the parishes of Beijing (where he was happier) and Shanghai (where he was less so). He learned Chinese, wrote poetry, and worked odd jobs here and there to make ends meet, including a stint as an interpreter for the Soviet news agency TASS (then called *Telegraph Agency of the Soviet Union*). He financed and peddled his own poetry collections, had a very close relationship with his mother (who had stayed behind in Harbin before joining him in Rio), and love affairs with men in both China and Brazil. With his younger brother he had more strained dealings. He attempted to emigrate to the United States in 1950 but was branded a communist spy due to his involvement with TASS and sent back to China, where he was then suspected of being an American spy. In 1952 he secured passage to Brazil for him and his mother, where both ultimately died in relative squalor and anonymity. He wrote and translated across Russian, Chinese, English, and Portuguese, and, despite being dislocated from the major centers of Russian diaspora, managed to keep in touch with fellow poets and scholars from both ends of Russia, as well as from Europe and the United States. This network of like-minded peers did not save him from dying in almost complete obscurity. Prolific and polyglot, he never made it into the circles of Brazilian intelligentsia, and has been all but forgotten in the country he died a citizen of. Since his death he has been mostly discussed within the context of Russian émigré poetry, and often just as an exotic footnote from the Far East (a queer subject,

a Chinese speaker, a Brazilian citizen). The irony of Valerii Pereleshin's biography is that he was such a marginal figure in his lifetime that in death he became the embodiment of intersectional cosmopolitanism.

In this article I do not wish to remain stuck in the mode of permanent rediscovery of this poet – I do not wish to keep on introducing him. Pereleshin has been the subject of excellent studies in recent years that can serve as roadmaps to his life and work, such as Olga Bakich's *Valerii Pereleshin: The Life of a Silkworm* (2015), Luc Beaudoin's *Lost and Found Voices: Four Gay Male Writers in Exile* (2022), Carlos Cortez Minchillo's 'A perspectiva canhota de um emigrado russo: expressão homoerótica na poesia de Valério Pereliéchin (1953-1992)' (2019), Li Meng's unpublished dissertation *Russian Émigré Literature in China: a Missing Link* (2004), Vitaly Chernetsky's 'Displacement, Desire, Identity and the 'Diasporic Momentum': Two Slavic Writers in Latin America' (2003), as well as publications by Mark Gamsa, O. F. Kuznetsova, Kadence Leung, Katya Knyazeva, among others. This article builds on this scholarship to propose three odd readings of this odd character who seemed (this is my interpretative stance and the wager of this text) unable to stop making questionable life decisions – including a commitment to lyrical poetry for a dwindling audience half a planet away. What I argue, ultimately, is that Pereleshin's very *eccentricity* – his radical off-centeredness, his refusal to inhabit the consolations of identity or belonging – is the condition of possibility for the emergence of a poetic voice that diverges sharply from the usual émigré attempts at self-healing or nostalgic return. Pereleshin was so lost to himself, he had gone back into himself so completely, that he came out the other side free.[5] But this hasn't made his life any easier. Philosophy can never serve as a consolation for poetry.

Patriotism as unfreedom

Unlike most foreigners I know in China, Pereleshin took the trouble of learning Chinese. Of really learning it, past the basic commands of ordering food and asking for another beer. He learned it so well that scarcely a scholar misses the opportunity to praise him for such feat, as if learning Chinese were impossible – or, deep down, just a waste of time. Olga Bakich notes that Pereleshin fell in love with Chinese and 'studied it almost in defiance.'[6] Simon Karlinsky speaks of Pereleshin as 'a rare example of a Russian writer in the Far East who took the trouble to study Chinese language and literature.'[7] Mark Gamsa echoes the assessment: 'In being able to read Chinese, he was almost unique among fellow Russian writers, just as he stood out as being both an Orthodox monk (between 1938 and 1945) and a homosexual.'[8] To speak Chinese as a foreigner is on par with being a homosexual Orthodox monk – an eccentricity at best; an invitation

for ostracism at worst. In a different article Gamsa explores the constitutive racism in the Russian émigré community toward Chinese people. He cites the short story 'The Root of Life' (1924) by Mikhail Shcherbakov (1890–1956), in which the main character 'becomes so sensitive to the smell of Chinese food stalls on a Vladivostok street that he feels an urgent need to escape from this culturally alien 'Chinese stench': 'The hunter felt sick of all these alien smells and sounds, he was pulled to a place where there were white people, not these slippery black figures, who gave out such a distinct smell of death.'' Gamsa cites this example as one among many to conclude that the prejudice displayed 'is so banal and routine, needing no explanation or justification, [that] it can be regarded as part of a value system shared by the author and his presumed readers.'[9]

It is the alien within us we discriminate and attack when we discriminate and attack the other. If the value system of the Russian émigrés in China was one in which belittling the Chinese population was a given, it was because through this manoeuvre they gained their own identity: their food allegedly does not reek – and, by extension, neither do they. The Russian émigrés needed the Chinese in order for themselves to be Russian outside of Russia – otherwise their own identity would collapse due to its own internal and unsustainable contradictions. The same might be said of other foreign groups in 1930s China, for whom, according to 'Shanghai old-timers, it is considered indecent in Shanghai to speak any language other than English, so attempts at 'indecency' are highly appreciated.'[10]

We are always implicated in what we see, even if the implication is to make ourselves feel bigger. Pereleshin compares the Russians living in Shanghai to 'drops in the sea': lost souls in a big city of a country that 'did not leave its mark on anyone in terms of language and culture,' and where 'one could live for decades without learning a single word of Chinese'[11] – a proud tradition carried on by expats even today. These were people who were trying not to feel 'demoralised' and who believed they would soon 'go home,' so there was no reason to invest themselves in a country that was so alien to them. According to Pereleshin, they 'did not notice China' – just as he did not, until he began learning Chinese in order to write a thesis on Chinese civil law. That's when he started to 'develop a deep love for China, its language and culture.'[12] In other words, that's when Pereleshin started to alienate himself, to detach himself from a value system and truly become his own person. That's how he was able to avoid chinoiserie and instead describe a China 'that really exists, with people and towns with which he has established real contact.'[13] That's when he started to notice that the Russian bubble he lived in was a bubble within a bubble: that, in a way, as cosmopolitan as Harbin, Beijing, and Shanghai may have been,[14] there was still a sense of isolation connecting the Chinese and Russian worlds.[15] This feeling of dislocation and otherworldliness is beautifully

captured in his poem 'The King' (Король), written in 1973 and published in 1976s *Ariel*:[16]

I saw the King of Norway:
He passed beneath a red and blue banner high –
Like us, but with the certain sway,
For everywhere he stepped, the land was his to ply.

Here the hills and fields are strange,
Yet he strode through them with pride and grace,
Though no Arctic sagas rang their range
To cheer the hero-line he traced.

In Managua, in Monrovia, in Paris
The monarch keeps his laws as his own:
Even in Lima, northern ice he carries.

And so into Moscow's mournful skies,
You bring with you your otherworldly guise – Transtemporal, extraterritorial!

Норвежского я видел короля:
Он проходил под красно-синим флагом –
Подобный нам, но с тем бесспорным благом,
Что под ногой везде его земля.

Здесь чуждые пригорки и поля,
Но и по ним прошел он гордым шагом,
Хоть не дано звенеть полярным сагам,
Праправнука героев веселя.

В Манагуа, в Монровии, в Париже
Хранит монарх законы, но свои же:
Лед севера и в Лиме не забыт.

Вот так и ты в московский Мір печальный
Вноси с собой потусторонний быт –
Вневременной, экстерриториальный![17]

The only advantage the king has over us is that the king owns the land he steps on, but that doesn't tether him to it any more than it does us. The king's advantage is material – a fortune Pereleshin has never enjoyed for too long. Every little bit of capital Pereleshin managed to save up was then spent on publishing his own poetry. Through self-publication he achieved squalor, perhaps inadvertently proving that poetry is the one true antidote to the accumulation of capital. Even the vocabulary and punctuation he uses as the poem reaches its apex – otherworldly, transtemporal, extraterritorial, exclamation mark – is underselling how many times he has lost everything

and was forced to reinvent himself, master a new language, find a new job, adopt a new pronunciation for his name. Luc Beaudoin argues that Pereleshin's world 'is filled with a worship of emptiness (…), but that emptiness brings with it potential, waiting to be undressed, and possessed, through poetry.'[18] This is precisely what Hegel means by alienation: loss – losing oneself – has a gain attached to it. Emancipation occurs only when the subject can recognise and identify with that which undermines them.[19] If Pereleshin is also someone who is trying not to feel 'demoralised' by a historical conjuncture that keeps getting in the way of his flourishing (as he imagines it), that keeps him not only from going home but from even *having* a home to go back to, isn't it then a much cleverer manoeuvre to embrace the loss as a positive instead of trying to recuperate it? Isn't it much cleverer to say, as Li Meng does of Pereleshin, that 'if home was not the place where he could be and wanted to be, then it lost its significance as home'?[20]

Slavoj Žižek remarks that 'it is the very movement of 'getting lost' (…) that opens up the space for the ethical work of mediation which alone can generate the solution. The loss is thus not recuperated but fully asserted as liberating, as a positive opening.'[21] Žižek will expand on this idea (in a text about Islam) to suggest that a certain level of alienation – by which he means social distance, by which he means European social distance – between individuals can actually be beneficial for peaceful coexistence: 'globalisation will turn explosive not if we remain isolated of each other, but, on the opposite, if we get too close to each other.'[22] The argument does what Žižek does best – polemics –, but it is not radical enough (or maybe at all), as it doesn't disturb in the least notions like globalisation, tolerance, and citizenship. He is in many ways accommodating the status quo of the imperialist hierarchy – a world that, now as in 1930s and 1940s China, treats nationalities like bank accounts: 'In Shanghai, perhaps, British and French nationalities meant the highest deposits, while pre-revolutionary Russian nationality . . . meant a deficit. The imperialist hierarchy of the world was nakedly apparent.'[23] Pereleshin's alienation, in contrast to Žižek's, seems so politically haphazard and non-programmatic as to become a powerful tool in questioning the narrow confines of bureaucratic allegiances such as one's citizenship. Both Olga Bakich and Anna Pasteka remind us that Pereleshin was required to accept Soviet citizenship if he wished to continue working at TASS. He accepted the Soviet passport without attaching any political significance to it,[24] and a few years later – on a ship bound to Brazil – threw it overboard: 'I did not want a Soviet passport. Let sharks eat it.'[25]

The passport had caused him (and his family) more trouble than it was worth, the bank of citizenship is neither naïve nor fair – it knows currency only holds value when it is scarce. It is rather his apparent aloofness in accepting the passport and campiness in getting rid of it that speaks to a provocative mindset seeking neither conformity nor polemics, but whatever is available. It

follows the path of least resistance, which is the hardest path to take, as it requires us to let go of the most entrenched confines of our personality just to be able to adapt. To adapt, to be flexible and not linear, to experience self-opposition rather than to entrench oneself in one's own beliefs, is profoundly disturbing to us because it forces us to see the world – and ourselves – as endlessly inadequate and alien. This realisation lies at the core of Pereleshin's famous theory of 'spiritual left-handedness': people are divided into 'those who are guided by the imperatives of the species and by racial and family traditions, and those who have liberated themselves from such imperatives and have thereby become spiritually and metaphysically 'left-handed.'"[26]

There is a level of camp in being gauche, as without camp gaucherie would amount to little more than a sad performance. Camp is what allows us to read irony into gaucherie ('Let sharks eat it'); it is what produces a distancing effect that allows us to see the world as alien and not as an extension of ourselves (it's not a passport, but a 'passport' – to paraphrase Susan Sontag's famous definition of camp: 'It's not a lamp, but a 'lamp'').[27] Yet, as Eve Sedgwick reminds us, camp also participates in what she calls a *reparative impulse* – 'additive and accretive,' driven by the desire 'to assemble and confer plenitude onto an object that will then have resources to offer to an inchoate self.'[28] To view Pereleshin's gestures through this reparative lens is to understand his campiness not merely as detachment or parody, but as an attempt – however doomed or excessive – to gather the fragments of multiple, estranged worlds into a liveable form. Applying camp here is an interpretive stance: while Pereleshin's poetry – and actions – often display campy qualities, this reading of his eccentricity may not reflect how he experienced or intended it himself. This is the wager of the text: to read campiness into an action – like throwing his passport into the ocean – not as a reflection of intention, but as a performative gesture that opens a space for imagining alternate modes of belonging, identity, and desire, highlighting the queerness inherent in negotiating multiple worlds at once.

Instead of entrenching himself in his Russianness, Pereleshin accepted whatever was available, which happened to be the Brazilian citizenship. Did he ever wish or dream of becoming Brazilian? Certainly not – the country did not exist to him until it did. But once it did, it made sense to him, as things only can once we stop struggling against them. In a letter dated April 13, 1976, Pereleshin writes: 'In the United States I would have turned out a professor of Russian literature at best; in Brazil I turned out to be a poet. There I would have lentil pottage; here I have the birthright' [В США из меня получился бы, в лучшем случае, профессор русской литературы, а в Бразилии получился поэт. Там я имел бы чечевичную похлебку, а здесь приобрел право первородства.][29] This 1976 letter is a campier reworking of the last three stanzas of his 1971 poem 'Three Homelands' (Три родины):

Fate seems a simple thing:
One day delight, the next despair,
I was driven out of China,
As from Russia – forever gone from there.

An outcast again, but no longer oppressed,
I give the remainder of my days
To Brazil, little known, unblessed,
My last homeland.

The air is thick, almost corporeal,
And rising in it, a sorcerer's spell,
These old fragments of songs will die out,
Signifying nothing at all.

Казалось бы, судьба простая:
то упоенье, то беда,
но был я прогнан из Китая,
как из России – навсегда.

Изгой, но больше не забитый,
я отдаю остаток дней
Бразилии незнаменитой,
последней родине моей.

Здесь воздух густ, почти телесен,
и в нем, врастая в колдовство,
замрут обрывки давних песен,
не значащие ничего.[30]

Fate is a simple thing for those who can resist the pull of linear thinking and are willing to embrace being an outcast again and again. The fact that it is simple does not make it any less exhausting – or life-threatening. But what good does it do to keep trying to force a square where only a circle will fit? What good would it do to Pereleshin to try and recreate Russia in his tropical backyard? If the Brazilian air is 'almost corporeal,' could it not then also serve as a new body to him? Vitaly Chernetsky notes how Pereleshin's writing 'went radically against the grain of conservative, 'defensive' nationalism' and instead 'elaborated a paradigm of augmentation and subversion of the Russian national form through openly embracing the potential of cultural hybridity and challengingly suffusing his texts with a queer problematic.'[31] Pereleshin uses Cyrillic to recreate Brazilian and Chinese sounds; he downplays his Russianness by claiming to hail from a Polish-Belorussian lineage;[32] he confesses to an 'inclination toward Roman Catholicism' and an 'aversion to 'normal sex;''[33] he wants to protect the Russian language from 'Soviet spoilage,' so he builds his 'conservative neologisms (…) in accordance with the

spirit of the Russian language, made from good Russian roots'[34] – and then proceeds to use this language to write progressively more homoerotic poetry and translations that go unpublished in the émigré circles worldwide and in Russia itself.[35] Ultimately, through his body of work, did Pereleshin subvert any notions of Russianness? Definitely not in the Kremlin. At least not openly. There's nothing grandiose about what he did beyond the fact that he did it: 'These old fragments of songs will die out / Signifying nothing at all.'

This is Pereleshin's alienation, as well as his campiness: he does not fight against his surroundings, because the world is not matter for him to shape according to his needs (he might have learned this from Daoism[36]). Things don't go his way, and yet he sees life through, he doesn't quit halfway, he manages. He is too camp for the self-seriousness of Romanticism, and too aloof for the epistemic violence of the Enlightenment and its self-serving promises of agency and mastery. He shares a quality with the best stand-up comedians: he never overstays his welcome, he leaves when the applause is at its peak. Pereleshin is the best of guests, better even than a comedian: he doesn't even show up; he sends a letter instead.

'Without pain there is no poetry, just biography'[37]

In Brazil, Pereleshin lived among 'books, dirty dishes, and filled ashtrays'[38] – a sign that he either didn't want visitors or desperately needed them. He was described as 'engaging, if eccentric'[39] by people who probably only meant the former as a compliment. Regardless, there is no doubt that he was indeed an eccentric, and his eccentricity is the link connecting what I am positing as his campy sensibility to his aloofness.

Pereleshin had a temper: he would pick fights and hold grudges – against acquaintances, university departments, whole countries; he would fall in and out of love and go from enamoured to caustic in a heartbeat; he was both too filial (he was practically married to his mother, with whom he lived in seclusion until her death in 1980[40]) and not filial enough (he could not provide for his ailing and aging mother – they were supported by his allegedly homophobic younger brother, much to his chagrin[41]); he never climbed the ranks of Brazilian intelligentsia – or became the subject of posthumous scholarly interest[42] – despite having spent half his life in the country. But perhaps Pereleshin's biggest eccentricity was that he was a poet. He might berate himself for not having picked up a trade in his youth (aloof), but is quick to confess that if his life were to begin again, he 'would most likely have chosen the same path'[43] (campy). He would have almost comedically doubled down on the same gaucherie, which prompts Evgeny Vitkovsky to wonder why someone who has not earned absolutely any money with his Russian poems in his lifetime would further dedicate his time to translating poetry,

knowing that the best he could get out of this arrangement would be to earn a reputation as an eccentric of otherworldly proportions (можно было заработать разве что репутацию чудака не от мира сего). To which Vitkovsky himself replies: 'Because love is selfless' (Затем, что настоящая любовь – бескорыстна).[44]

Even if Vitkovsky's words were meant as praise and not judgement, I cannot help but read frustration into his conclusion that a man of Pereleshin's linguistic and intellectual stature may have had to forgo a life of greatness and resign himself to one of eccentricity, as if eccentricity were a consolation to failure. But at the same time I also wonder if it is not precisely because Pereleshin failed in the pragmatic sense of the word that he was able to create such an odd and polysemic body of work. His eccentricity – meaning: his off-centeredness, his radical de-centering, his queerness – is the very condition of possibility for the appearance of a poetic voice that sets itself apart from the usual Russian émigré output with its edifying attempts at healing either their own exiled selves or the loss of their Mother Russia. Pereleshin's alienation implies that there is no healing in the sense that our bodies are never completely healthy or diseased – it is always a combination of both. In his own words: 'No matter in what bed you put the patient, the illness will remain.'[45] We can never get whole: there will always be a split within us that we must mediate. No drug can ever cure us – we are forever caught in mediation, partly healthy, partly sick.

In Pereleshin this split is externalised, dramatised: his need to mediate the world is exacerbated by geography, citizenship, sexuality, codes of sociality. His need to mediate the world and his alienation from its codes *become* the core of his poetry. Alexis Klimoff draws our attention to 'Pereleshin's persistent tendency to emphasise the human failings of the individuals with whom he comes into contact,'[46] as if his gaucherie were contagious, as if, despite being 'engaging,' there were something about his eccentricity that prevented him from cracking the code. Pereleshin himself complains to his friend Peter Petrovich Lapiken that people may praise his work, but they refuse to associate with him: '[Vladimir] Weidlé praises *From Mount Nebo* but does not want to write a review: he uses 'employment' as an excuse.' [Вейдле хвалит «С горы Нево», но отзыв писать не хочет: отговаривается «занятостью».][47] Even as a teenager Pereleshin had trouble navigating the eccentricity of his desire, and the only friend he had was also the source of his infatuation. But, unable to crack the code either way, 'the exceptionally bright Iura [Georgii] Volkoff' ultimately became neither close friend, nor lover: 'The desire was naturally there, but I could never overcome my shyness: there were never any words.'[48] If sociality is the ability of finding the appropriate words for every occasion, eccentricity is then the ability of coming up with the exact wrong ones at all times.

I am resigned (though inwardly I scream).
You, too, must now endure the hurt of failure.
Try to snatch but a half an hour from your jailer.
Don't be ashamed of self-abasing gestures,

Or else, he will snuff out on the spot.
All of our dreams and hopes for an encounter,
And, victim of a modern immolation,
They'll dump you at the foot of Lenin's tomb.

A living dog's more blessed than dead lions.
You'd better lie. Humiliate yourself.
For cover, use some shreds of a red banner.

God doesn't ask you for insane bravado.
He knows that when you trample on the icons
You still have not betrayed your inner self.

Смирился я (пусть молча, но крича),
Стерпи и ты обиду поражений
И, не стыдясь просительных движений,
Хоть полчаса урви у палача.

Иначе он расправится сплеча
С надеждою мечтаемых сближений,
И жертвою для новых всесожжений
Тебя снесут к подножью Ильича.

Льва мертвого и пес живой блаженней,
Так лучше лги, не бойся унижений,
Прикрой себя обрывком кумача.

Не просит Бог безумных одолжений
И ведает, что, обра3à топча,
Ты все-таки не сделаешься Лженей!

This is 1973s 'Not for Publication' (Не для печати),[49] and I read it as a response to my perceived frustration in Vitkovsky's lament vis-à-vis Pereleshin's fate. In this poem we see the speaker coming to terms with failure rather than resisting it. The vocabulary is not defeatist – this is a particularly poignant and powerful piece of writing *because* it is so devoid of phallic power: to abandon all bravado, 'A living dog's more blessed than dead lions.' The touching dignity of this poem comes from its lack of investment in a more successful version of the speaker's life that has not materialised. The speaker is not lamenting what could have been but asserting what is and how the foundation of what is is mired in sacrifice, discomfort,

contradiction. Luc Beaudoin argues that when it came to interpersonal relationships, Pereleshin's voice ultimately 'was always alone,'[50] but it seems to me that this loneliness is not the endpoint of his life and work, but rather a byproduct of his coming to terms with his own alienation and lack.

This 'lack' is a recurring motif in his 1976 poetry collection *Ariel*, from which this poem is taken. There, in 'Links' [При посылке «звена»], he makes an almost Lacanian point: that a metal chain is not connected by the rings, but by the gaps between them ('В сыром углу металл без дела ржавел, / Теперь он – цепь, докована она, / И мы в цепи – два смежные звена: / Я лучшие в них зерна переплавил').[51] This idea – that the hole is what holds a chain together – underscores the whole collection: in it, Pereleshin reenacts from beginning to end a love affair with a man he never met, a (married) man who once wrote him a letter from Moscow to express his admiration for his work and who then became first his muse, then his antagonist. They go through the motions – or, rather, Pereleshin does – without the inconvenience of domesticity: in 'To the Ailing One' (Больному), when his beloved gets sick, the speaker gets sick too, but only metaphorically, which is the best way to fall ill: 'I am very far away – but near you' ('Не дядя, не отец, по-дальнему любя, / Я очень далеко – но около тебя: / Твой жар и бред, и пот, – я их приму на веру, / Себе на рамена и на стихи взвалю. / Потом, качаясь в такт печальному размеру, / Всей верностью моей я тоже заболю').[52] The speaker thrives in his epistolary generosity, in how available he can be from afar; he yearns physical contact (in 'The Letter from Afar' – Письмо издалека) but is cured by the very act of longing ('И все-таки я вылечен тоской / И вознесен любимостью такой – / Блаженнейшей – над пропастью тройною').[53] And as the epistolary romance starts to fall apart, as the speaker fails to find the appropriate words, he raises a cup (in 'The Cross' – Крест) to his beloved and utters the most beautiful words two lovers who wish to preserve the memories of their love can say to each other:

> And yet, in our disunion.
> We are joined by an invisible toast:
> May we never visit each other

> И все-таки в разрозненности нашей
> Мы сближены невидимою чашей:
> Пусть мой к тебе несбыточен приезд[54]

The gap of love

For Pereleshin, '[f]riendship is almost love,'[55] and real love is platonic ('Любовь эта платоническая и, вместе с тем, очень страстная. Она явно обречена на неудачу').[56] What love and friendship have in common

is that both require distance: to be social means to know how to keep one's distance from the other; to be in love is to be in love with an absence. Distance is at the core of *Ariel*, it is Pereleshin's *objet a*:[57] not what you get but what prevents you from completely fulfilling your desire. Distance is what resists our colonisation, what is in the object more than the object (what is in love more than love). Distance is, in many ways, Pereleshin's main quality.

This insight is made abundantly clear in the titles of some of his poems collected in *Ariel*, such as 'To the Barely Known' (Едва знакомому) and 'In Separation' (В разлуке). Pereleshin spells it out in the latter: 'Eyes need eyes, and living hands require – / Responsive hands, submissive to their will, / And that is why the vulgar lovers tire – / They cannot bear when separation strikes still' [Глазам нужны глаза, живым рукам – / Ответные податливые руки, / И потому влюбленным пошлякам / Не устоять под натиском разлуки.][58] One word strikes the reader as a painful accusation: пошляк – vulgar, superficial. The figure of the vulgar lover captures something central to Pereleshin's oeuvre: resentment. Poetry – and letter writing – allows Pereleshin to manage the condition of desiring what he believes he deserves (fame, stability, recognition) but cannot obtain for reasons beyond his control. The speaker is assumed to stand in contrast to this vulgarity, unable to partake in the bad faith of those who believe their subjectivities can ever coincide perfectly with themselves, that they can ever abolish the distance between self and the social or symbolic positions they occupy at any given time – a state we might call bliss.

This bliss is unavailable to Pereleshin, all too aware of his 'left-handedness,' and so what he can do is to manage his resentment the way one loves objects or the dead. Kierkegaard argues that the most unselfish love is love for the dead, since this love reveals itself fully without demanding reciprocity.[59] Pereleshin, in writing, likewise expects nothing in return – also in the most literal sense: not from editors (he self-published his work), not from institutions (his forays into American universities and Brazilian academies yielded nothing), not from patriotic ties (he claimed to have transcended race, caste, and faith[60]). He is not that vulgar.

But those same verses also reveal a need: 'Eyes need eyes, and living hands require – / Responsive hands, submissive to their will' – in other words, eyes to read his letters, hands to write him back. Pereleshin needed an audience more than he needed domesticity. He longed for the distance that comes with an audience: the ability to control the narrative to some extent, to be seen without seeing, or to see without being seen. In praising separation and distance, Pereleshin underscores the fact that the satisfaction we derive from love, from being with others, lies in the gap between what we see and what we get, between presence and absence – and it is this gap, to quote Alenka Zupancˇicˇ, that turns the banal object into the sublime:[61]

'The subject is separated from the object by an interval or gap, which keeps moving with the subject and makes it impossible for him ever to catch up with the object. The object that the subject is pursuing accompanies him, moves with him, and yet always remains separated from him, since it exists, so to speak, in a different time zone.'[62] Could there be a more fitting definition of the mystery of Pereleshin's long, queer, and anonymous life than that of a subject who exists in a different time zone?

A different time zone: 'And yet, in our disunion / We are joined by an invisible toast: / May we never visit each other.' Domesticity banalizes love, makes it vulgar, normal. Better to keep love alive through letters, through brief encounters (or none at all), through making love on Saturday night and celebrating the liturgy the next morning[63] – or even through cruising: 'At the crossroads, near the vitrines, / Where women's glances are franker – / Still more enticing are the eyes of men. / Amid touches and movements, / Flirtingly you nudge / A neighbour you fancy, / Peering sharply beneath his hat / And, in passing or with malice, / Dropping a clever word.'[64] Better to embrace what we have long ago understood, however reluctantly, resentfully: 'that 'normal' life was not for me.' This was Pereleshin's way of putting his foot down as his mother urged him to marry ('there are devoted and loving women') and to have children. 'I did not succumb,' he wrote. 'I cannot think of my affair with a married wench (a society lady) without shuddering: how repulsive all that was!'[65]

There is no evidence that Pereleshin ever read Freud, but his approach to love and friendship – both by choice and necessity – echoes Freud's insight that normality is an ideal fiction: up close we are never normative, we are always the exception. Freud (and Pereleshin) suggest that the normative, the universal, the pervasive can only be grasped through the exception, through difference, through distance. It is from this insight that we can understand the bright and unashamed instances of camp in Pereleshin's poetic voice. And it is from here that we can find campy humour (and pain) when he writes in 'Invitation to Paradise' (Приглашение в рай) that 'Marriage is not a sin, but a major disadvantage.'[66]

A different time zone: Everything that happened in Pereleshin's life happened too late. He was born too late (he would have preferred the Middle Ages, the Renaissance, or even early nineteenth-century Russia). He learned Chinese too late to make it his profession. He went to Brazil too late to become a Portuguese-language poet. He was admitted too late to Harbin Law School. And he died fearing that his friends' efforts to secure some sort of international recognition for his work were also coming too late.[67] Always alienated, caught in an unassailable distance, he made the distance and the alienation his own. He cast not only his passport but also himself to the sharks. In a poem he shared with his friend Emmanuel Sztein in 1969 titled 'Faces' (лици), Pereleshin describes himself and his plight:

The last – but also the first –
Pereleshin will come, a poet;
He will complain about his nerves,
He will cover the light with a lampshade.

Последним – но он же и первый –
Перелешин придет, поэт,
Пожалуется на нервы,
абажуром прикроет свет.[68]

A different time zone: It's not a lamp, it's a lampshade.

Notes

1. Meng Li and Richard D. Sylvester, "Valerii Pereleshin at the International Poetry Festival in Austin, Texas (April 1974)," *Toronto Slavic Quarterly* 14 (2005), http://sites.utoronto.ca/tsq/14/sylvester14.shtml.
2. Paul Franco, *Hegel's Philosophy of Freedom* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1999), 106.
3. Mari Ruti, *A World of Fragile Things* (New York: State University of New York Press, 2009), 43; 49.
4. Todd McGowan, *Emancipation after Hegel: Achieving a Contradictory Revolution* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2019), 198.
5. G. W. F. Hegel, *Hegel and the Human Spirit: The Jena Lectures on the Philosophy of Spirit of 1805–6*, trans. Leo Rauch (Detroit: Wayne State University Press, 1983), 159.
6. Olga Bakich, *Valerii Pereleshin: The Life of a Silkworm* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2015), 22.
7. Simon Karlinsky, "'Russian Culture in Manchuria and the Memoirs of Valery Pereleshin,'" in *Freedom from Violence and Lies: Essays on Russian Poetry and Music*, ed. Robert P. Hughes, Thomas A. Koster, and Richard Taruskin (Boston: Academic Studies Press, 2013), 316.
8. Mark Gamsa, *Harbin: A Cross-Cultural Biography* (Toronto: University of Toronto Press, 2020), 208.
9. Gamsa, "On the Value Systems of the Russian Émigrés in China," 164.
10. O. F. Kuznetsova, "«Я Оказался в Этом Сером и Неинтересном Городе … »: Из Шанхайских Писем Валерия Перелешина Матери, 1943–1946," *Литературный Факт* 4, no. 14 (2019): 150.
11. Jan Paul Hinrichs, "Valerij Perelešin, Een Dichter Met Drie Vaderlanden," *Groniek* 91 (1985): 65.
12. Hinrichs, 68.
13. Jan Paul Hinrichs, *Russian Emigré Literature in the Twentieth Century Studies and Texts*, Vol. 4 (The Hague: Leuxenhoff Publishing, 1989), xxix.
14. Karlinsky, "'Russian Culture in Manchuria and the Memoirs of Valery Pereleshin,'" 318.
15. E. V. Kapinos, E. Yu. Kulikova, and I. V. Silantiev, "Русский Китай Как Историческая Летопись и Как Лирический Сюжет («Поэма Без Предмета» и «Два Полустанка» В. Перелешина)," *Сибирский Филологический Журнал* 2 (2017): 99.
16. Unless otherwise indicated, all Russian translations are our own.

17. Valerii Pereleshin, *Ариэль* (Frankfurt am Main: Possev-Verlag, 1976), 85.
18. Luc Beaudoin, *Lost and Found Voices: Four Gay Male Writers in Exile* (Montreal: McGill-Queen's University Press, 2022).
19. McGowan, *Emancipation after Hegel*, 63.
20. Li, "Russian Émigré Literature in China: A Missing Link," 485.
21. Slavoj Žižek, *The Parallax View* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 2006), 127.
22. Žižek, "The Antinomies of Tolerant Reason: A Blood-Dimmed Tide Is Loosed," *Lacan.com* (blog), accessed October 4, 2023, https://www.lacan.com/zizantinomies.htm.
23. Leo Ou-fan Lee, *Shanghai Modern: The Flowering of a New Urban Culture in China, 1930–1945* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1999), 318.
24. Anna Theresia Pasteka, "China Lesen Und Träumen: Valerij Perelešins Dichtung Und Übersetzungswerk" (University of Vienna, 2013), 10.
25. Bakich, *Valerii Pereleshin: The Life of a Silkworm*, 133.
26. Karlinsky, "A Hidden Masterpiece: Valery Pereleshin's Ariel," 304.
27. Susan Sontag, *Against Interpretation and Other Essays* (New York: Noonday Press, 1966), 280.
28. Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick, "Paranoid Reading and Reparative Reading, or, You're So Paranoid, You Probably Think This Essay Is About You," in *Touching Feeling: Affect, Pedagogy, Performativity* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2003), 149–50.
29. Pereleshin, "Письма П. П. Лапикену [Letters to P.P. Lapiken]." Letter forty-fifth, April 13, 1976.
30. Pereleshin, *Три Родины*, 114–15.
31. Vitaly Chernetsky, "Displacement, Desire, Identity and the 'Diasporic Momentum': Two Slavic Writers in Latin America," *Intertexts* 7, no. 1 (2003): 67.
32. Bakich, *Valerii Pereleshin: The Life of a Silkworm*, 6.
33. Hinrichs, *Russian Emigré Literature in the Twentieth Century Studies and Texts*, xxii.
34. Pereleshin, "Письма П. П. Лапикену [Letters to P.P. Lapiken]." Letter nineteenth, March 9, 1975.
35. Evgeny Vitkovsky, "Валерий Перелешин: Неизданные Переводы На Русский Из Уильяма Шекспира, Луиса Де Камоэнса и Фернандо Пессоа," *Toronto Slavic Quarterly*, no. 7 (Winter 2004), http://sites.utoronto.ca/tsq/07/perelishin07.shtml.
36. James Miller, *China's Green Religion: Daoism and the Quest for a Sustainable Future* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2017), xix.
37. Pereleshin, "Письма П. П. Лапикену [Letters to P.P. Lapiken]." Letter thirty-third, August 4, 1975.
38. Carlos Cortez Minchillo, "A Perspectiva Canhota de Um Emigrado Russo: Expressão Homoerótica Na Poesia de Valério Pereliéchin (1953-1992)," *Journal of Lusophone Studies* 4, no. 1 (2019): 115.
39. Bakich, *Valerii Pereleshin: The Life of a Silkworm*, 247.
40. Minchillo, 115.
41. Bakich, 223.
42. Minchillo, 114.
43. Bakich, 223.
44. Vitkovsky.
45. Bakich, 57.

46. Alexis Klimoff, "Review of 'Russian Literary and Ecclesiastical Life in Manchuria and China from 1920 to 1952: Unpublished Memoirs of Valerij Perelešin. The Hague: Leuxenhoff Publishing, 1996. Xviii, 140 Pp.,'" *Canadian-American Slavic Studies* 35, no. 2–3 (2001): 315..
47. Pereleshin, "Письма П. П. Лапикену [Letters to P.P. Lapiken]." Letter fifteenth, February 14, 1975.
48. Bakich, 23.
49. Pereleshin, *Ариэль*, 81. English translation by Simon Karlinksy.
50. Beaudoin.
51. Pereleshin, *Ариэль*, 45.
52. Pereleshin, 55.
53. Pereleshin, 63.
54. Pereleshin, 68.
55. Hinrichs, xxii.
56. Pereleshin, *Ариэль*, 4.
57. Jacques Lacan, *Transference. The Seminar of Jacques Lacan, Book VIII*, ed. Jacques-Alain Miller, trans. Bruce Fink (Cambridge: Polity, 2015).
58. Pereleshin, *Ариэль*, 159.
59. Søren Kierkegaard, *Works of Love*, trans. Howard V. Hong and Edna H. Hong (New Jersey: Princeton University Press, 1995), 349.
60. Bakich, 131.
61. "In love, we do not find satisfaction in the other that we aim at; we find it in the space or gap between, to put it bluntly, what we see and what we get (the sublime and the banal object)." Alenka Zupančič, "On Love as Comedy," *Journal of Gender, Politics and Culture* 2, no. 1 (2003): 78.
62. Zupančič, 73.
63. In a letter dated July 23, 1975, Pereleshin speaks of his "adventures with boys" [приключения с мальчишками]: "At that time, I liked the young bookseller Liu Xing (or Liu Tian Sheng). He seems to have fallen in love with me even more than I fell in love with him. But he could only come to me on Saturdays. And after such nights with him, I went to celebrate the liturgy." [Приглянулся мне в ту пору юноша-книготорговец Лю Син (или Лю Тянь-шэн). Кажется, он влюбился в меня еще больше, чем я в него. Но приходить ко мне он мог только по субботам. И после таких ночей с ним я шел совершать литургию.] "Pereleshin, "Письма П. П. Лапикену [Letters to P.P. Lapiken]."
64. "На перекрестках у витрин, / Где взгляды женщин откровенней, / Призывнее глаза мужчин, / Среди касаний и движений, / Заигрывая, подтолкнуть / Понравившуюся соседку, / Под шляпку зорко заглянуть

    И добродушно или едко / Словечко меткое ввернуть." Hinrichs, *Russian Emigré Literature in the Twentieth Century Studies and Texts. Vol.4*, 5. The translation is ours.
65. Bakich, 41.
66. "А брак – не грех, но крупный недостаток." Pereleshin, *Ариэль*, 122.
67. Pereleshin, "Letter to Emmanuel Sztein, 27/12/1971," 1971.
68. Pereleshin, "Letter to Emmanuel Sztein, 11/5/1969," 1969.

Acknowledgments

The early stages of this research were also supported by a small grant from the Center for the Study of Contemporary China (CSCC) at Duke Kunshan University, to which I am grateful.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).